German Idealism Reading Group

Columbia University

Faculty Sponsor: Axel Honneth

Topic: The Philosophy of Nature.

Description: This group investigates major authors associated with the project of '*Naturphilosophie'* in German philosophy around the turn of the 19th Century. Authors we will study include Kant, Goethe, Schelling, and Hegel. Topics include the philosophical interpretation of space, time, motion, matter, the organized character of the universe as a whole, natural forces, light, shape, magnetism, electricity, and life.

Schedule of Readings

Week **Reading(s)**

1 First Formulations of the Project for a Philosophy of Nature

- Kant, MFNS: "Preface" (pp. 3-14 / [467]-[479])
- Schelling, IPN: "Introduction" (pp. 9-42)

Optional further readings:

- Schelling, IPN: "Exposition of the General Idea of Philosophy as Such, and of the Philosophy of Nature in Particular, as a Necessary and Integral Part of It" (pp. 43-55)

2 Later Formulations of the Philosophy of Nature

- Schelling/Fichte, PRFS: "Correspondence" (pp. 41-50 / 13.-15.)
- Hegel, PN: "Introduction" (pp. 1-25 / §245-251)

Optional further readings:

- Schelling, FOSPN: "Outline of the Whole" (pp. 5-11 / [67]-[74])
- Hegel, PN: "Introduction" (pp. 25-27 / §252)

3 Nature as an Organized Whole

- Kant, CJ: "Analytic of Teleological Judgment" & "Dialectic of Teleological Judgment" (pp. 257-264, 277-288 / 377-384, 395-404)
- Schelling, FOSPN: "First Division" (pp. 13-34 / [77]-[101])

4 Schelling on the Priority of the Organic

- Schelling, FOSPN: "First Division" (pp. 35-70 / [101]-[134])

5 Space, Time, & Motion

- Kant, MFNS: "Metaphysical Foundations of Phoronomy" (pp. 15-18, 20-29 / [480]-[483], [485]-[493])
- Hegel, PN: "Mechanics" (pp. 28-44 / §254-261)

Optional further readings:

- Kant, CPR: "Transcendental Aesthetic" (pp. 157-167 / B37-B58)

6 Kant's Theorization of Matter & Its Forces

- Kant, MFNS: "Metaphysical Foundations of Dynamics" (pp. 33-74 / [496]-[535])

7 Hegel & Schelling on Matter

- Schelling, IPN: "On Attraction and Repulsion in General, as Principles of a System of Nature", "General View of the System of the World", "First Origin of the Concept of Matter", & "The Construction of Matter" (pp. 143-152, 171-181)
- Hegel, PN: "Mechanics" (pp. 44-62 / §262-268)

8 Gravity

- Schelling, FOSPN: "Second Division" (pp. 71-78 / [134]-[144])
- Hegel, PN: "Mechanics" (pp. 62-84 / §269-271)

9 Light

- Schelling, IPN: "Of Light" & "Concerning the Theory of Light in the Philosophy of Nature" (pp. 68-86)
- Hegel, PN: "Physics" (pp. 85-105 / §272-280)

Optional further readings (on color):

- Goethe, TC: "General Characteristics" (pp. 273-291 / 688-732)
- Hegel, PN: "Physics" (pp. 182-217 / §317-320)

10 Electricity & Magnetism

- Schelling, FOSPN: "Second Division" (pp. 78-94 / [144]-[158])
- Hegel, PN: "Physics" (pp. 158-178, 220-232 / §308-315, §323-325)

Optional further readings:

- Schelling, IPN: "Of Electricity", "On the Construction of Electricity in the Philosophy of Nature", "Of the Magnet", & "The Doctrine of the Philosophy of Nature on Magnetism" (pp. 96-129)

11 Roots to the Study of Life in the Philosophy of Nature

- Kant, CJ: "Analytic of the Beautiful" & "Analytic of Teleological Judgment" (pp. 64-65, 239-257 / 219-220, 362-377)
- Hegel, PN: "Organics" (pp. 311-321 / §345)

Optional further readings:

- Goethe, MP: "Introduction", "Of Seed Leaves", "Transition to Flowering", "Formation of the Calyx", "Formation of the Corolla", "Formation of the Stamens", "Formation of the Style", "Linnaeus's Theory of Anticipation", & "Recapitulation" (pp. 5-44, 56-74, 97-103 / 1-50, 67-81, 107-123)

12 Plant Life

- Schelling, FOSPN: "Third Division" (pp. 105-110, 113-130, 141-149 / [170]-[177], [180]-[196], [210]-[219])
- Hegel, PN: "Organics" (pp. 273-277, 303-311, 321-322, 336, 342-343, 350-351 / §337, §343-349)

Optional further readings:

- Schelling, FOSPN: "Third Division" (pp. 110-113, 130-141 (recommended) / [177]-[180], [196]-[218] (recommended))
- Hegel, PN: "Organics" (pp. 336-342, 343-350 / §347a, §348a)

13 Animal Life

- Hegel, PN: "Organics" (pp. 351-360, 372-399, 406-420 / §350-370)

Optional further readings:

- Hegel, PN: "Organics" (pp. 360-372 (recommended), 399-406 / §354a (recommended), §365a)

Abbreviations

Kant, *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science* – MFNS

Kant, *Critique of Judgment* – CJ

Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason* – CPR

Goethe, *Metamorphosis of Plants* – MP

Goethe, *Theory of Colors* – TC

Schelling/Fichte, *The Philosophical Rupture between Fichte and Schelling* – PRFS

Schelling, *Ideas for a Philosophy of Nature* – IPN

Schelling, *First Outline of a System of the Philosophy of Nature* – FOSPN

Hegel, *Philosophy of Nature* – PN